



Retreat at Bull Run

After the battle, the Union Army retreated in total confusion to the fortifications around Washington. Military wagons and the carriages of fleeing spectators blocked their route, and many men were captured.

Union plans—and weaknesses

McDowell conducted his attack on Beauregard's position partly in response to the heavy political pressure exerted by overconfident and overeager Northern politicians. The Union commander fretted that "for the most part our regiments are exceedingly raw and the best of them, with few exceptions, not over steady in line."

Although the Confederate army was smaller (McDowell commanded 35,000 men), it fought on the defensive—a potent advantage when considering two ill-disciplined, indifferently trained, and inexperienced armies. Nevertheless, McDowell's battle plan also had merit, as he hoped to turn the Confederate left flank by ordering two divisions to cross Bull Run Creek at points upstream from the bulk of Confederate strength near Blackburn's Ford.

Most regiments elected their own officers, reflecting Jacksonian America's traditional suspicion of hierarchy and technical proficiency. Nevertheless, the volunteers' enthusiasm showed the ensuing conflict to be truly a "people's contest."